manufacturers lacked the expertise in this field, and it was important for the customers to have only the best, they were imported from France. The vaults were not only the first of their kind in India, but were fire and burglar proof, providing maximum security to the depositors. The depositors were also reassured that regardless of the financial status of their dealings with the bank, the bank had no claim whatsoever on the contents of the locker.

The bank achieved another first in 1924, when it employed women assistants to serve lady customers, and even maintained a separate department for them. This was done to encourage ladies to use the bank's services and also attract resources which would lie idle in the form of jewellery or other frozen assets. Shortly after it was set up, the department was serving 1,000 customers a month. The first to join the ladies department was Yasmin Surveyor, India's first woman commerce graduate, who had received her B.Com degree from Sydenham College, Bombay, in 1925.[8]

The ubiquitous cheque book given to savings bank account holders was also introduced by the Central Bank. Again, rupee travellers' cheques are something we take for granted today, but this innovation too was the result of some original thinking by the bank. It also broke new ground when it started administering estates on behalf of its clients, an activity managed by the Executor and Trustee Department. It was established in 1929 and was organized on the lines of the Trustee Companies in England. Within six years of its commencement in 1929, it had assumed the responsibility of administering more than sixty estates of an aggregate value of ₹60 lakhs, a measure of the confidence in the bank.

Another fruitful result of the Central Bank's original thinking was the Central Fixed and Flexible Trust Company, a precursor of the Unit Trust of India. In 1932, a novel scheme of insurance was launched through the Depositors' Benefit Insurance Company Limited affiliated to the bank to serve the twin objectives of bolstering the saving habit and protecting the interests of the dependants of deceased persons. The only condition was that the insurer should maintain an average daily balance of ₹10 in his savings account. In a short time, 5,000 policies of a total value of ₹40 lakhs were issued. It was also about this time that the bank opened a number of Mandi Pay Offices in Punjab, injecting a rural and agricultural bias into the Central Bank's policies. The Mandi offices were situated in villages where